

A show of architects for . . . anybody

Beyond the world of real buildings and clients, there's another world of ideas.

New ideas are not Boston's strong point and, though the town is full of architects, it's never been a cultural capital in architecture — at least not since the fifties when Walter Gropius and the annual urban design conferences at Harvard made it so.

Yet this is a time when consensus is breaking up, when ideas are seething.

In other cities, such as New York, Philadelphia, Chicago, even Los Angeles, there have been controversial shows, excited manifestos, heated forums. The New York Five, the Chicago Seven, the Whites, the Grays, the Silvers — all are the monikers, slightly ironic, not of political sects but of architectural ideologies.

Most of the debate has been in New York over the past three or four years, especially in the Museum of Modern Art, its offshoot the Institute for Architecture and Urban Studies, and the latter's house organ "Oppositions" (published by MIT Press).

Though the tone of the debaters is often unbelievably self-important, the issues really matter. Some of this activity is at last rubbing off on Boston.

ARCHITECTURE/ROBERT CAMPBELL

A young Boston architect, Warren Schwartz, returned from last year's "Chicago Seven" show and wondered whether something like that couldn't be done here. With two friends, he persuaded the prestigious Hareus-Krakow gallery to open its space for an exhibit of Boston architects.

The exhibit, "Immanent Domains," opened this week and runs through Oct. 1.

The idea was to have each architect design the same thing — a house — so that differences in philosophy could emerge.

Besides the three who organized the show, there are six other architects. They fall into two groups — the usual two these days.

The first camp tends to see the architect as artist. It emphasizes an austere formal beauty, a highly charged, mute, symbolic presence. Architecture is not what serves the user or his needs, but what remains after he's gone. This group is well represented by a "Country House" by Rodolfo Machado.

The second camp tends instead to make buildings that are loose, talky,

full of detail, shapeless. This group is preoccupied with the problem of reconciling architecture with everyday culture. There's great interest in the inhabitant, what he will do, what he will see, how the building will work as a stage set for life. A house for a site in Newton, Mass., by Alice and Donlyn Lyndon represents this group.

Both groups, of course, are in full flight from "functionalism." Just as no one, apparently, ever voted for Nixon, no one, it turns out, really believed in functionalism.

There are other points in common. Both groups delight in pastiche — searching through history for hints of other buildings, other times, which they incorporate into their designs in the manner of "The Wasteland" or an early Rauschenberg. But where Machado's house recalls Palladio, Lyndon's remembers breakfast nooks and the Newton streetscape. Where Machado seeks resolution, Lyndon welcomes division.

Among the other architects here, Jan Wampler designs a summer house for twenty people on Monhegan Island, real people whose photos and comments are an integral part of the pres-

entation. Of all the architects, Wampler cares most about site and inhabitant, seeing himself as providing a framework others will later change and improve.

Jorge Silvetti offers an interesting formal exercise in which a house is made of a stair wrapping around an empty cube. Inhabitant, site and detail don't exist, nor does the likelihood of future change. Louis Bakanovsky explores, not entirely convincingly, the idea of a house that would be a limitless grid of possibility. Thomas Amsler has a relatively conventional walled-off family preserve opening to the ocean.

Warren Schwartz and Robert Silver, two of the show's organizers, design a glass bowfront house that reminds you of Robert Venturi and Robert Stern but is justified in terms of solar efficiency.

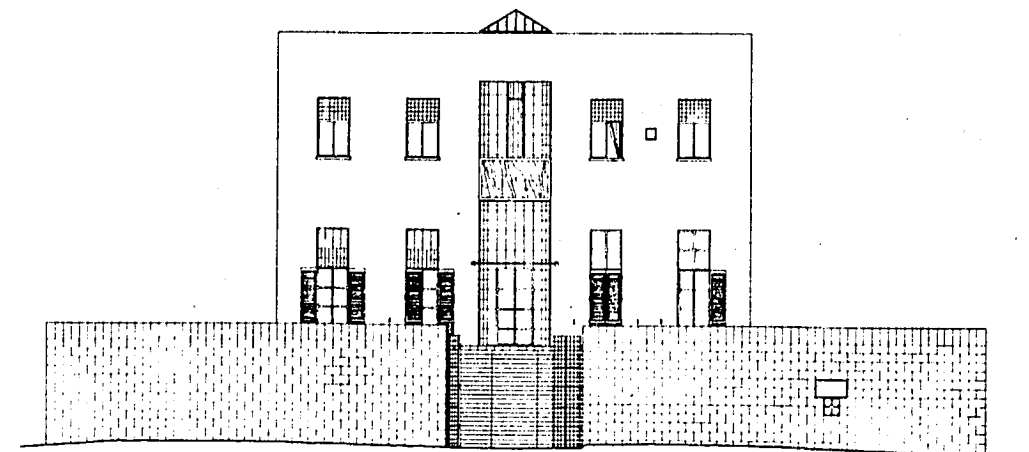
Francis McGuire, the third organiz-



House for a site in Newton, Mass., by Alice and Donlyn Lyndon, is as loose and contradictory as Machado's is firm and resolved. Drawing styles reflect this. Says Lyndon: 'Places to live in are not puzzles that fit only one way.'

er, offers the most self-involved of the designs and justifies it boldly: "I am primarily interested in architecture as a structure which rewards the careful observer with information as to the intentions of its creators."

Quality is very uneven and the choice of participants seems arbitrary. But those are minor objections. It's exciting to see a show like this in Boston. I hope a lot of people besides architects will go.



'Country House' by Rodolfo Machado, echos the work of Italian Renaissance architects. It's a rigid, formal design

in which each room is a kind of chapel, with a fireplace, fountain or other object acting as altar.